



ALBUM TIME: Anand with wife Mona, children Suneil and Devina

HUGE BLOW-UPS OF RICHA SHARMA WERE LYING ON THE TABLE IN MY BEDROOM. MONA GLARED AS I KEPT LOOKING AT THEM.

INDIRA GANDHI
"The dumb doll title fitted her like a glove"



I met Indira Gandhi again after she was made the information and broadcasting minister in Lal Bahadur Shastri's government. She was very amiable and hospitable, and receptive to the film industry's problems, but spoke very little. In fact, every time I met her, she was more of a listener than a speaker. And every time I wondered whether the title of 'the dumb doll' given to her by her political opponents was based on factual reality. I got more and more convinced that it fitted her like a glove. At the screening of the English version of *The Guide* for her governmental approval and clearance for its worldwide release, the only two sentences she spoke to me were 'You speak so fast!' and 'We shall send you the clearance certificate soon.' Another time, I spent more than half an hour with her, and again carried the impression that she talked very little and was mostly a quiet listener, betraying no reaction, positive or negative, on any topic.

film finished, she met the most important man in her life, Sanjay Dutt, and destiny gave her life another direction.

'Are you married?' Allena, our Czech interpreter, had abruptly asked me. I preferred not to answer, some innocent mischief tickling me. 'If I go to India and if you asked me not to come back here, I would stay on there,' she put it across very frankly. There was a hint of flirtation in her eyes and tone, which enamoured me. I kissed her hand. Back in India I received a light-blue envelope by post. It carried a Czech postmark. There was nothing written except a big question mark. Did she want an answer to the question, 'Will you marry me?' I felt elated. In Karlovy Vary, Allena said she was sorry since she did not know I was married. The chauvinistic male in me instinctively asked, 'Do you still wish I was-n't?' 'I do,' she confessed openly. I looked into her eyes. There was a desire in them, a longing. Back in our hotel suite, Mona threw a tantrum. 'Who is that girl?,' she said through clenched teeth. 'I don't trust you. You send me back immediately,' she exploded, and started crying.

The one who had loudly applauded me stepped forward to say, 'Lovely shot!' Before I could say, 'Thanks you', she already had come out of the group holding an autograph book. 'Sorry for the intrusion! But can I have your autograph?' she said. I looked at her. 'Why not?' I said, and took the autograph book to oblige her. 'Ever thought of being in the movies?' I asked. 'I don't care.' 'Would you care to come for a screen test?' 'If you insist.' 'I do.' The smart fresh-faced sixteen-year-old with a beautiful smile, Tina Munim, was selected to play the leading lady in *Des Pardes*. Having Tina next to you was as good as having a sparkling glass of red wine being offered to you. She was naughty, mischievous and frivolous, a cute girl that everyone was fond of.